

MentorMatch

CodeCrafters & Blondinele

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Project Part 1 - Understanding the Problem

Overview of the Problem

Modern professionals and learners face a persistent challenge: although the desire to develop new skills is widespread, the path to finding the right guidance is fragmented, impersonal, and often discouraging. People who want to grow in areas such as leadership, communication, data analysis, public speaking, artificial intelligence tools or project management typically encounter a set of compounding obstacles.

First, there is an information abundance problem: learning resources are plentiful (online courses, YouTube tutorials, books, podcasts), yet the sheer volume makes it difficult to know where to start or which resources are most relevant to one's specific goals and experience level. Second, human mentorship, which research consistently identifies as one of the most effective accelerators of professional and personal development, is difficult to access. Most people do not have an established network of experienced mentors and informal mentorship often happens only through fortunate personal connections.

Third, even when a potential mentor exists within one's network there is no structured mechanism for matching compatibility in terms of learning style, communication preferences, scheduling constraints or domain expertise. As a result promising mentorship relationships either never form or dissolve quickly due to poor fit.

Core problem statement: People seeking skill development cannot efficiently find, evaluate and connect with compatible mentors while experienced professionals willing to share knowledge lack a channel to reach motivated learners.

A dedicated digital platform is necessary to solve this problem because the matching, scheduling, communication and progress-tracking requirements involved exceed what can be handled through existing general-purpose tools (e.g., LinkedIn, email). A purpose-built system can encode domain knowledge about learning goals and mentoring styles into a matching algorithm, provide structured onboarding for both mentors and mentees and create a continuous feedback loop that improves match quality over time. MentorMatch is designed to fulfill this role.

User Characteristics

Data Collection Methodology

The primary data collection method for this project was artifact analysis of a product demonstration video produced by the MentorMatch team (Echipa Blondinele). The video served as a rich observational artifact, presenting the platform's intended workflows, interface structure, user personas and value propositions in a naturalistic walkthrough format.

The video provides a firsthand account of the envisioned user experience directly from the platform's creators making it a high-validity primary source for understanding design intent. Artifact analysis allows for repeated and careful examination of interaction flows without the scheduling constraints of interviews or surveys and the video offers a complete and structured representation of the problem space available.

Additionally, a discussion was held with the MentorMatch team regarding the application, informed by documentation they provided.

Primary User Groups

The application targets active professionals, generally ranging between 20 and 60 years old. While the users have varied levels of overall digital competence, it is assumed they possess at least basic skills for navigating web applications, completing digital profiles, and using standard organizational tools. Importantly, the platform must account for users with special needs, particularly with visual impairments, requiring compatibility with screen readers, adjustable text (font, size, color), and voice recording or calling options.

Mentees - These users are early-career professionals motivated by a desire for rapid skill development and career advancement. The platform also appeals to university students (particularly in the final year of study), entry-level candidates, career changers and freelancers seeking domain expertise with different motivational drivers and time horizons for their learning goals. Key characteristics include:

- Technical comfort: high familiarity with digital platforms and mobile applications
- Motivation: career growth, skill gap closure, and continuous professional development
- Pain points: lack of professional network, uncertainty about learning direction, limited access to experienced guidance
- Behavioral patterns: goal-oriented, value personalization, expect responsive and asynchronous communication

Mentors - This user group consists of experienced professionals who are willing to share their expertise. Their key characteristics include:

- Experience level: mid to senior career stage, typically 5 or more years in a domain
- Time constraints: limited availability; mentoring is a secondary activity
- Expectations: a low-friction platform that respects their time, with clear communication from motivated mentees
- Technical comfort: moderate to high
- Dual-Role capability: mentors are not restricted strictly to teaching; a mentor can also act as a mentee at the same time to develop their own skills in other areas

Task Analysis

Characteristics of User Tasks

The tasks performed by users of MentorMatch fall into two broad categories aligned with the two user roles. For mentees, the primary task flow is oriented around discovery, matching and learning. For mentors, the task flow centers on profile creation, availability management and session delivery.

Key task characteristics include:

- Frequency: Profile creation and onboarding occur once; session booking and attendance are recurring; feedback and progress review occur periodically
- Duration: Onboarding tasks are expected to take 5 to 15 minutes; session scheduling takes 2 to 5 minutes; actual mentoring sessions range from 30 to 60 minutes
- Complexity: Matching configuration is moderately complex (requires input on interests, goals, experience and format preferences); session management is low complexity
- Error sensitivity: Incorrect match preferences can lead to poor matches, which is a high-cost error since it may discourage continued platform use
- Interdependence: Mentee tasks are highly dependent on the actions of mentors (availability, responsiveness) and vice versa

Task Environment Characteristics

MentorMatch is a digital platform expected to operate primarily as a web application. The task environment has the following characteristics:

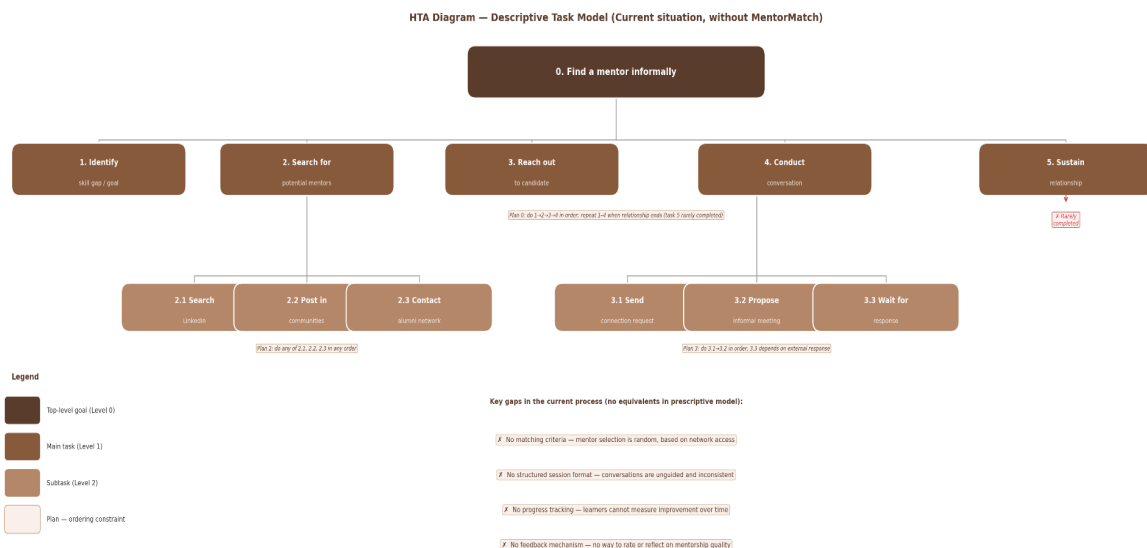
Dimension	Characteristics
Physical setting	Users operate in professional or home office environments

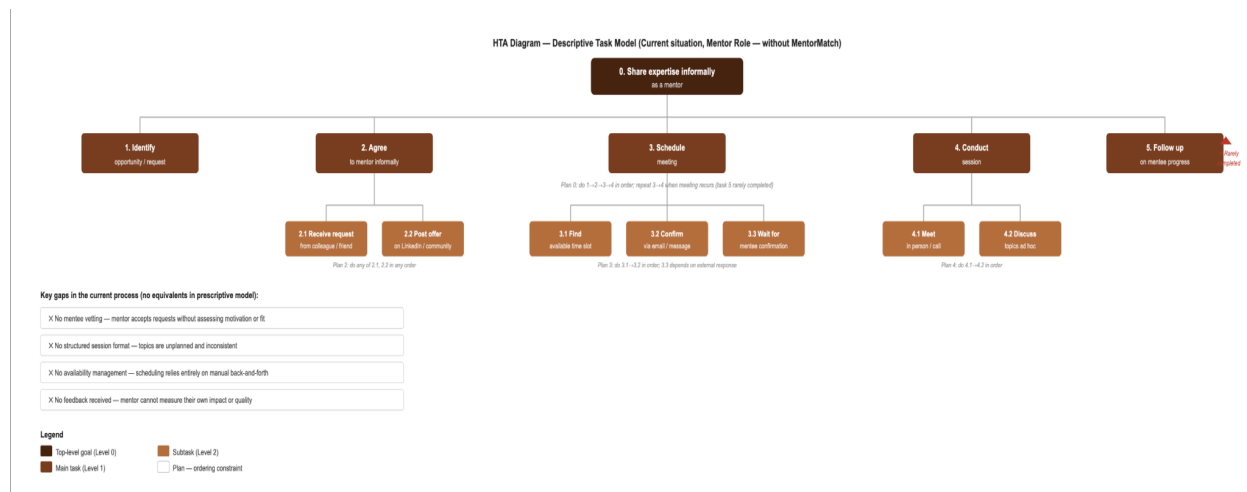
Dimension	Characteristics
Interruptions	High probability of interruptions during onboarding and browsing; sessions require dedicated, uninterrupted time
Device context	Web/Desktop environments
Time pressure	Low during onboarding; moderate during session scheduling (coordinated calendars); high during live sessions
Social context	Primarily solo use, but sessions involve synchronous interpersonal communication requiring trust and psychological safety
Connectivity	Reliable internet assumed for video sessions; platform should degrade gracefully on slower connections for non-video tasks

Task Models

Descriptive Task Model (How users currently address the problem)

In the absence of a dedicated platform, the current task of finding a mentor follows an informal and fragmented process. A descriptive account of how young professionals currently seek mentors is as follows:

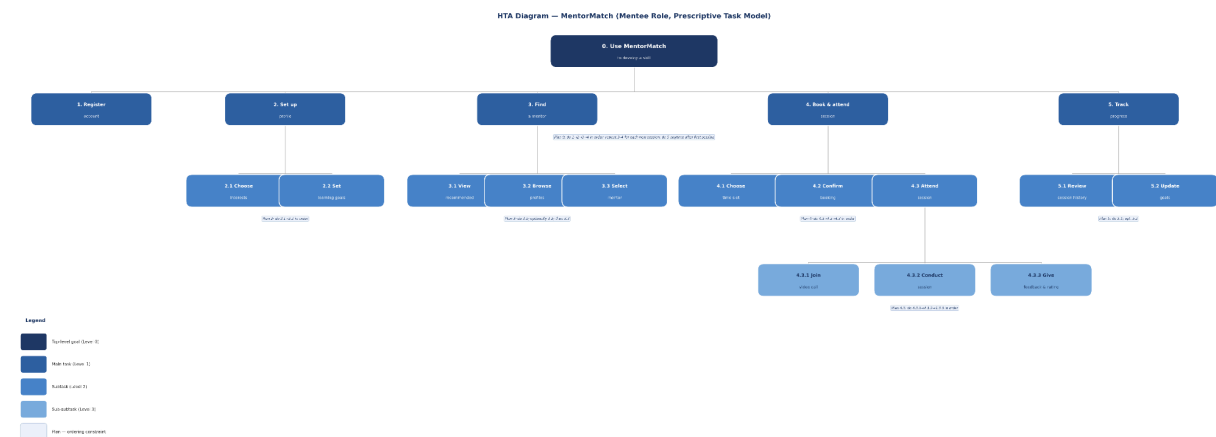




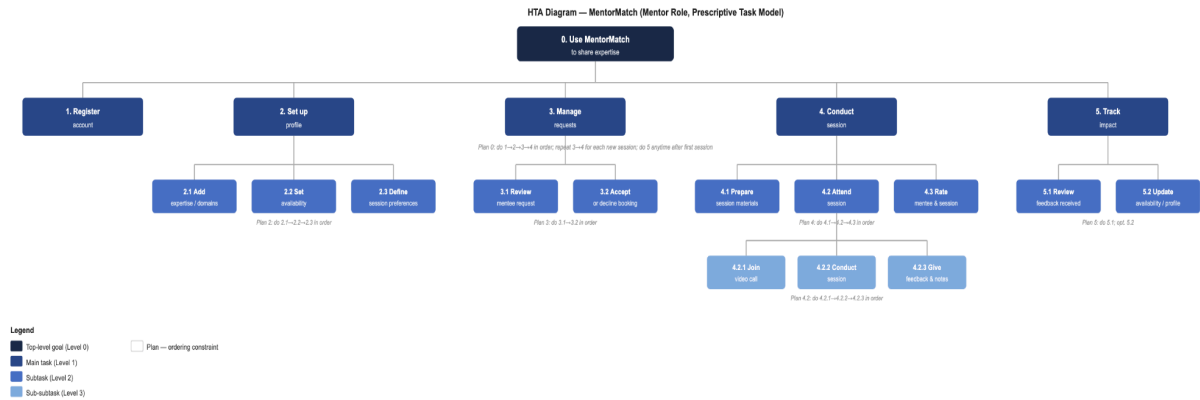
This process is inefficient, success-dependent on social capital, entirely unstructured, and lacks any progress tracking or feedback mechanism. The match quality is essentially random.

Prescriptive Task Model (How MentorMatch structures the ideal task flow)

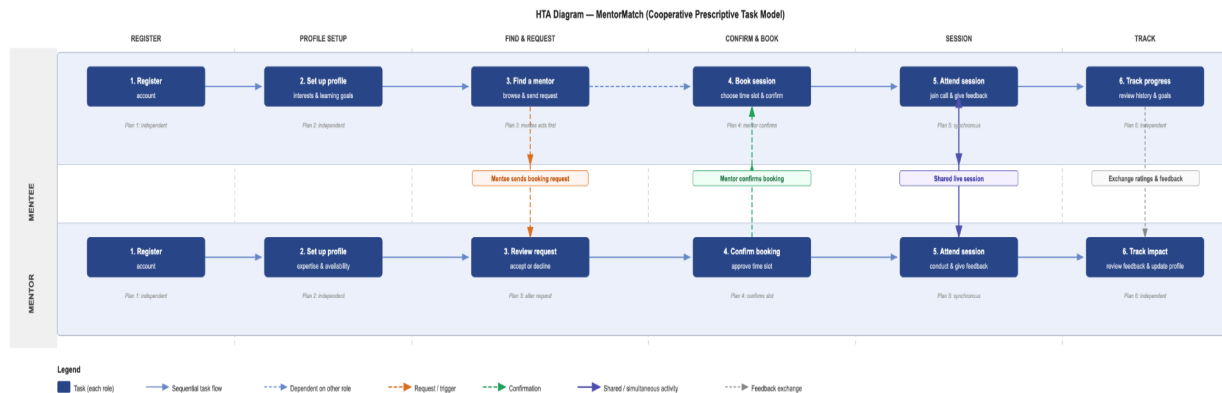
MentorMatch prescribes a structured, guided workflow for the mentee:



For mentors, the prescriptive flow is symmetrically simpler: register, create a profile highlighting expertise and availability, receive match requests, confirm sessions, deliver sessions, and receive feedback.



Cooperative Prescriptive Task Model (How Mentee and Mentor collaborate within MentorMatch)



The cooperative task model describes the full interaction between both roles across six shared phases. Unlike the individual prescriptive models, this model highlights the points of dependency and synchronisation between the Mentee and Mentor.

Analysis of the Existing System

The existing system being replaced is not a single competing platform but rather the collection of ad-hoc tools and informal processes described in the descriptive task model above. Additionally, several competing or adjacent platforms serve portions of the same need. The following table summarizes the strong points and deficiencies of the current landscape:

System/Tool	Strong Points	Deficiencies
LinkedIn	Large professional network; verified credentials; InMail messaging	Not purpose-built for mentorship; cold outreach has low response rates; no session structure or progress tracking

MentorCruise	Dedicated mentorship platform; structured sessions; payment model rewards mentors	Paid model creates barrier for budget-constrained young professionals; limited matching intelligence
ADPList	Free mentorship platform; growing community; calendar integration	Lower vetting standards for mentors; limited matching algorithm sophistication; no integrated learning resources
LinkedIn Learning / Coursera	High-quality structured content; certificates; wide domain coverage	Entirely impersonal; no human mentorship component; low completion rates due to lack of accountability

MentorMatch's key differentiation lies in the combination of intelligent matching based on multi-dimensional user profiles, integrated session management, learning resources and progress tracking within a single platform. The absence of any one of these components characterizes the failure modes of existing solutions.

Social and Technical System Context

Social Context

MentorMatch operates at the intersection of several significant social trends. The rise of lifelong learning as a professional norm means that skill development is no longer confined to formal education; employees are increasingly expected to self-direct their growth.

The platform also interacts with the shift toward remote and hybrid work, which has simultaneously increased the need for informal professional connection and reduced the organic opportunities for mentorship that would naturally arise in a physical office. Young professionals in particular report feeling isolated from senior colleagues in remote-first environments, making a digital mentorship platform particularly timely.

There are also important social dynamics of power and trust embedded in the mentorship relationship. Mentees are typically in a more vulnerable position, sharing professional insecurities and learning gaps with a relative stranger. The platform design must account for this asymmetry by building in trust signals (mentor credentials, reviews, session history) and clear norms around confidentiality and professional conduct.

Technical Context

From a technical perspective, MentorMatch must integrate with or be compatible with a set of existing tools that users already rely on. Calendar integration (Google Calendar) is essential for session scheduling. Notification systems are necessary for timely communication.

The matching algorithm is the core technical differentiator. Its quality directly determines the perceived value of the platform. At minimum, it must process structured inputs (domains, goals, experience, format preferences) to rank mentor compatibility. Over time, behavioral data (session attendance, feedback scores, goal completion rates) should inform a more sophisticated recommendation engine.

Data privacy and security are critical technical constraints. The platform handles sensitive professional information and interpersonal communication. Compliance with GDPR and clear control over data visibility are non-negotiable requirements.

Initial Usability Criteria

The following usability criteria were created based on the task analysis above by using Claude AI.

Criterion	Target and Measurement Method
Onboarding completion rate	Target: 4 out of 4 users complete full profile setup within 15 minutes. Measurement method: Time each participant with a stopwatch.
Session booking time	Target: 4 out of 4 users complete session booking (selecting mentor, choosing time slot, confirming) in under 5 minutes. Measurement method: Time the booking task from mentor selection to confirmation.
User satisfaction	Target: Average score of 75 or above across all 4 participants. Measurement method: Administer the System Usability Scale questionnaire after testing.
Learnability	Target: 4 out of 4 users complete the end-to-end flow (register, match, book) without assistance. Measurement method: Observe and record whether each participant completes all tasks independently.

Implications for Design

The Onboarding Experience is Mission-Critical

Because the primary user group consists of early-career professionals and university students who are accustomed to high-quality digital product experiences (Spotify, Instagram, Duolingo), the onboarding flow must be polished, progressive and immediately rewarding. A lengthy, form-heavy registration will result in abandonment. The design should use progressive disclosure, showing only what is necessary at each step and should provide instant value (e.g., a preview of available mentors) before profile completion is required. The first perceived match should feel personalized and credible, not generic.

Trust Signals are Non-Negotiable

Given that mentees are sharing professional vulnerabilities with strangers and mentors are investing their limited time, both parties need robust trust signals. This means mentor profiles must display verifiable credentials, experience and authentic user reviews. The design must make it easy to assess mentor credibility at a glance, using visual hierarchy to surface the most trust-relevant information (years of experience, domain, rating, number of sessions completed) without overwhelming the viewer.

Matching Must Be Transparent and Correctable

An opaque algorithm that produces poor matches will be perceived as a platform failure, not a technical limitation. The design should explain, in simple language, why a particular mentor was recommended. Users should be able to adjust match preferences without restarting onboarding. This implies the matching interface needs both a results view and an accessible settings layer.

Mentor Experience Determines Supply-Side Health

The platform's long-term viability depends on retaining active, quality mentors. Since mentors are time-constrained and their participation is largely altruistic, the design must minimize friction for mentor-side tasks: scheduling, session participation and feedback. Any unnecessary complexity on the mentor side will erode supply and ultimately harm the mentee experience. This suggests that mentor and mentee interfaces should be designed as distinct experiences, not as a single unified interface with role-based access.

Progress Visibility Drives Retention

One of the most significant failure modes of informal mentorship is that learners have no way to track whether they are actually progressing. MentorMatch has an opportunity to close this loop through structured goal tracking and session history visualisation. The design should make progress feel tangible and motivating, using visual representations of completed milestones and skill development over time. This is not merely a nice-to-have feature; it is central to the platform's core value proposition of accountable, outcome-oriented learning.